Uber courier?
The ride-hailing service will soon deliver Xiaomi phones to impatient customers in Malaysia and Singapore.
http://dgit.in/UberCourier

A legend passes away
Nintendo's president Satoru Iwata passed away at the age of 55 due to Bile Duct Tumor. The entire gaming community mourns his loss.

the "power of divergence", as he calls it. So, your current competitors are the products you're hoping will go obsolete as a result of your invention. Indirect, but still competition. Use their services, enter into a dialog with them. Through their website or sales contact person, they'll inadvertently divulge information on the market. A caveat: take this advice with a pinch of salt.

Interact with potential consumers and partners

Then, speak to potential consumers and possible alliances as well. Say you're launching a platform for the medical community that brings together all medical practitioners on a single page or connects patients to medical services, like Practo. You'll talk to patients who'd be interested in using your services. You'd also talk to doctors and pathology labs, among others, to understand their support for such a program and sign them up. While having this conversation, you'll not only understand what its selling features are, but also derive a growth hack. These partners in turn become your POS (point of sales).

Do your primary research

Social media is a great tool for primary research. Tools such as Facebook, Twitter and Whatsapp allow you to connect with many people from all demographics across the country. Running a Facebook ad for a few weeks will prove to be cheap and insightful. Doing this will allow you to talk to your potential customers in their comfort zone where they'll be more open. The earlier stage when you have personal interactions acts as a good starting point and the start of a partnership. However, asking people for their opinions and feedback in real time puts them on the spot and most people don't like to be exceptionally rude and discouraging. So you might walk away with a hunky dory impression. Always, take findings from personal interactions with a grain of salt. As Vinay says, "What people say is not what people do". Create a benchmark score to understand which product components the users like and which they don't. Facebook rates the effectiveness of your ad campaign on a scale of 1 to 10. The closer to 10 you are, the better the ad was received by your target audience. So you can create multiple ads highlighting the different features of your product and run them across your target demographic. The one that attracts the most consumers is the feature that you should ideally focus on. Primary research is mainly used to validate your assumptions of the consumer's needs and product value propositions.

Now go back to your original plan and incorporate these findings.

PROTIP: GET 20-20 VISION

To inspire your potential stakeholders, you need a perfect vision statement. Forbes has done a fantastic job of explaining why most company vision statements aren't effective. Read it here: *http://dgit.in/uncomplicate*

Now you know what NOT to do. But you still need to know how to get it right. For a better understanding on formulating a vision statement, go here: *http://dgit.in/gdvision*

Proof of Concept (POC)

By this stage, you should be able to create a basic version of the product. This will include only a couple of the value propositions that have been validated. This is your "proof of concept" or "POC". To know whether your concept has real-world application, it must be tested. To test this beta version, form a focus group, usually consisting some of your potential customers and the partners you spoke to during the research phase – they'll most likely agree to do this. Generate plenty of feedback in the beta testing stage. Some of the key questions you should seek to answer are: "Where's the consumer coming from?", "Where are they spending time?" and "What's their next step?" To answer these questions, assuming you have a website-driven product, use Google Analytics to analyse the pattern and flow of visitors. If not, create custom surveys and ask your customers to fill them out. This should give you the final iterations to your business plan.

Once you've developed a POC, you're good to approach Angel investors to move to the next stage.

Who are these Angel investors?

An angel investor is a high net worth individual (HNI) who's willing to place a bet on you and your idea. Basically guys with a lot of money to throw around. Of course we kid, they're shrewd as hell, which is why they have all that money in the first place! Most of these angel investors are entrepreneurs or tycoons themselves like the Bansals of 'Flipkart' or Bhavish Aggarwal of 'Ola Cabs' or Aprameya Radhakrishna and Raghunandan G of 'Taxi For Sure' fame. Remember, any entrepreneur who has made it big can be a potential angel investor – be it your very own rolling in money landlord or hero worshipped cricketers such as Yuvraj Singh (who has created the 'YouWeCan Ventures'). Even industry stalwarts such as Ratan Tata and Narayan Murthy, who set up 'Catamaran Investment', are known for their angel investing on the side. There are also crowdfunding initiatives such as 'Kickstarter.com'. Online platforms such as 'Paisaconnect.com' host a portfolio of investors to view and approach. Indian Angel Network (http://indianangelnetwork.com/) provides a platform for the angel investors to come together and create a bigger fund. Fund houses such as 'Sequoia Fund' are also beginning to ride the angel investment wave.

Venture Capitalists (in the years to follow)

A few years later, you'll want to grow further, maybe by expanding geographically, adding more product lines or beefing up your development/engineering and marketing team. This is where the venture capitalist steps in. Venture Capital (VC) firms are always professional funds that raise money from HNIs. They're always on the lookout for a company to invest in and generate returns for their clients. Funds from such firms are injected in three rounds called Series A, B and C funding rounds.

According to 'YourStory', India's media platform for entrepreneurs, $3.5 billion was injected into 380 disclosed deals in the first of half of 2015. Also check out http://dgit.in/vcdealss and http://dgit.in/dealszz for a deal by deal account compiled by trak.in.